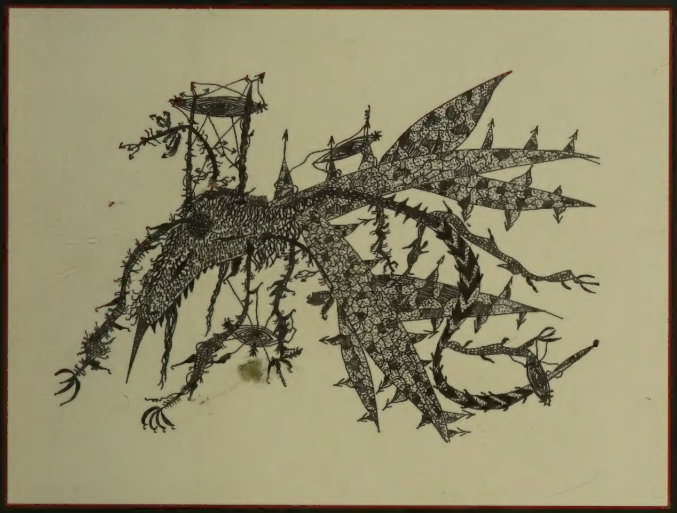
THE TRUMPETS OF JERICHO



Unica Zürn

TRANSLATED BY CHRISTINA SVENDSEN

Unica Zürn (1916–1970) was born in Grunewald, Germany. She worked as a secretary for Ufa (Universum-Film-AG), and toward the end of World War II, discovered the true nature of the Nazi concentration camps: a revelation that would haunt and unsettle her for the rest of her life. After meeting Hans Bellmer in 1953, she followed him to Paris where she became acquainted with the Surrealists and developed the body of drawings and writings for which she is best remembered: a series of anagram poems, and hallucinatory accounts and literary enactments of the mental breakdowns from which she would suffer until her suicide in 1970.

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CONTENTS

TRANSLATOR'S ACKNOWLEDGMENTS VII

TRANSLATOR'S INTRODUCTION IX

THE TRUMPETS OF JERICHO 1

TRANSLATOR'S ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

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TRANSLATOR'S INTRODUCTION

This fierce fable of childbirth by German Surrealist Unica Zürn is in many ways one of her strongest literary works, and yet, perhaps owing to its transgressive content, it is one of her last to finally be translated into English. Written after Zürn had already given birth to two children and undergone the self-induced abortion of another in Berlin in the 1950s, *The Trumpets of Jericho* dramatizes the frontiers of the body—its defensive walls as well as its cavities and thresholds—animating a harrowing and painfully, twistedly honest depiction of motherhood as a breakdown in the distinction between self and other, transposed into the language of darkest fairytale. The language forged through the course of the dreams of birth and death described here is the most valuable aspect of the novella: in it, we see Zürn swirl, agitate, and convulse her words until prose and anagram-poetry converge, creating an incantatory style of uncanny beauty.

From the start of the Surrealist movement, indeed from the moment of the founding of the Bureau of Surrealist Research in Paris in 1924, when Man Ray took his photograph of the founding members sitting underneath the statue of a naked female body suspended from the ceiling, the Surrealists insisted on the importance of being inspired by a female muse. These muses put the male artists in touch with the powers of the unconscious mind, through either madness or love. The earliest muse figures

were unnamed women: the hysterics kept as inmates of the Salpetrière hospital in Paris, whom Breton and Aragon celebrate in a rapturous 1928 article, "The Fiftieth Anniversary of Hysteria," in their journal *La Révolution Surréaliste*. Later, muses were usually wives or girlfriends of the artist: first Nadja, and then Jacqueline Lamba for André Breton; Meret Oppenheim and Lee Miller for Man Ray; Dora Maar, Leonora Carrington, Remedios Varo, Elsa Triolet, Gala Dalí. Many of these women were practicing artists who, sooner or later, broke out of the public role of muse and became recognized in their own right.

Unica Zürn is one of the later breakouts, and one of the darker muses. Although she had long been a journalist and writer of short stories, she became known as a member of the Surrealist movement by appearing on the cover of the journal *Le surréalisme même* in 1958. Photographed from behind in the nude by her partner, the artist Hans Bellmer, her torso is so tightly wrapped in twine that the string incises her body, making her appear inhuman, a formless slab of meat. Many viewers have also noted the resemblance between the petite Zürn and the images in Bellmer's "Doll" series, a sequence of photographs and paintings focused on disarticulated, headless girl dolls, often with more than four limbs, arranged in disquieting positions. Zürn and Bellmer were also aware of the uncanny resemblance, and commented on it in their first meetings. Zürn's own writing and drawing often focuses on questions of gender and power, circling back to certain types of entrapment and, laboriously, over and over, tracing lines of escape.

Zürn's writing and artworks have often been read as autobiographical. Literary historian Mary Ann Caws, one of the subtlest critics to write about Zürn's output, remarked in a catalog of Zürn's drawings published by the Drawing Center, that both of the two major fictions by Zürn heretofore translated into English, *The Man of Jasmine* and *Dark Spring*, are "autobiographical in feeling and in fact, although the facts were in the crucial cases to come later than the writing."[1] She refers not just to Zürn's 1960 diagnosis of schizophrenia, but also her suicide in 1970 committed by throwing herself out of a window, a death prefigured in her mother's manner of suicide and in the ending of her novella *The Man of Jasmine*. To some degree it is true that Zürn's art and her writing are "outsider art," works whose stunning originality is in part attributable to the greater access to the unconscious mind afforded by a proximity to madness—a proximity that many Surrealists celebrated as the true source of art. Yet this diagnosis offers too facile an explanation, doing disservice to the degree to which Zürn consciously and self-consciously shaped her art. Zürn had a twenty-year career as a writer behind her and had successfully staged several exhibitions of her drawings in galleries before her first diagnosis at the Karl-Bonhoeffer-Heilstätten in 1960 in Berlin. The catalyst for her shift from journalist to artist was her encounter in 1953 with Surrealism and with Hans Bellmer, not her later diagnosis.

Critical writing has tended for too long to accept Surrealist tropes of women's creativity as rooted in madness or childlikeness in the case of Zürn, even after such tropes have been dis-

missed by revisionist critics in relation to the other female Surrealists. Perhaps Zürn's wounds have been too obvious: her coded references in fiction to her rape as a child by her brother; her abortions in the 1950s; her difficult relationship with her dead mother, and her estrangement from her two own children after she lost custody during her divorce from her first husband in 1950; and finally, her deep psychic distress and projected guilt at the atrocities of the Nazis as revealed in the postwar period, an undistanced suffering that caused one of her breakdowns. The fiction of hers translated up until now has tended to reinforce this autobiographical interpretation, featuring protective male figures reminiscent of Bellmer and her friend Henri Michaux, traumatic sex, and visions of suicide by leaping through a window. *The Trumpets of Jericho* is an important corrective because it shows Zürn writing at the height of her powers, taking on troubling subjects such as dissolution, mingling, death, and birth, and writing with control, humor, and urgency. We see some biographical details interwoven, such as the poignant detail of the hotel L'Esperance ("Hope Hotel") at 88 rue Mouffetard, the Parisian hotel where Zürn and Bellmer first lived together in 1953, which becomes the home of the woman and the "little customer" in *Trumpets*. Yet the autobiographical is subordinated to the oneiric, the fairy tale, and the anagrammatic spell of language here. The novella opens with a woman isolated and physically being opened up by childbirth, but she takes charge of the pregnancy and child in a series of disturbing but highly evocative actions. It ends with a "headbirth," a daughter born like Athena from a

man's head, who multiplies like a trickster, manages her own reproductive strategies, and plays pranks on her hapless father. Men and women are both subject to the uncontrollable aspects of their bodies, and men and women cope with the aftermath.

The Trumpets of Jericho is above all about the liberatory and incantatory possibilities of language, as suggested in *Oracle and Spectacle*, the title of another work of hers from this period. The Book of Joshua tells us that God destroyed all of Jericho except for "the harlot Rahab" who had helped the Israelites, giving them the power to bring down the walls of Jericho by means of a powerful sound. "So the people shouted, and [the priests] blew with the horns. And it came to pass, when the people heard the sound of the horn, that the people shouted with a great shout, and the wall fell down flat, so that the people went up into the city, every man straight before him, and they took the city" (King James Bible, Book of Joshua, 6:20). This is the power that Unica Zürn seeks: language as magical action in the world.

As Nietzsche wrote on magic and prayer in *The Gay Science*: even after the death of God, "rhythm is a compulsion; it engenders an unconquerable desire to yield, to join in; not only the stride of feet but also the soul itself gives in to the beat—probably also, one inferred, the souls of the gods! By means of rhythm one thus tried to *compel* them and to exercise a power over them: one cast poetry around them like a magical snare."[2] Though Zürn uses alliteration and anagram as much as she does rhythm, her language is indeed an attempt to compel the forces surrounding her, as well as the power of her own unconscious.

Her writing recalls the earliest recorded German poetry, the magical spells or *Zaubersprüche* still included at the opening of German literary anthologies. Zürn's oracular language creates a kind of healing order through anagram on a tormented, fractured mind. *The Trumpets of Jericho*, in particular, is an attempt not only to knock down the walls (of the pregnant body, of consciousness separated from the unconscious mind), but also to conquer and even to reconcile with an enemy, and ultimately to find an uncompromising, unsentimental form of healing and power.

Anagram poetry is the most important source of the magical, creative power of language for Zürn, because anagrams tap into not just individual unconscious minds but the collective unconscious of language itself. Anagrams arise by accident and coincidence over the course of a language's evolution, later to be made use of by a poet. Anagrams therefore necessarily remind us of the contingent, external, and uncontrollable aspects of language. The linguist Ferdinand de Saussure, himself obsessed with anagrams that he found in ancient Roman poetry, called this a "cryptographic" aspect of language, the way in which words themselves could be dismembered and rearranged to generate poetry from a given language. In his postscript to Zürn's poetry collection *Hexentexte* (or "hexed texts," often known in English as *Witches' Writing*), Zürn's companion Hans Bellmer similarly claims that the anagram "acknowledges—in a slightly uncanny manner—that it owes more to the help of some "other" than to one's own consciousness."[3] Zürn must work with what is giv-

en—language and its inherent potential for anagram—but this restraint paradoxically creates a lack of restraint in the free rein from conventional sense-making that it gives to her powers of association and imagination.

Bellmer saw Zürn's anagrams as part of the Surrealist practice of automatism and automatic writing that he shared with her. Chance plays a role in what she writes, but her own mind inflects what chance gives, to create an accurate "weather report of the self"[4] over time. Bellmer writes beautifully of Zürn's results, describing them as "language-images that cannot simply be thought up or written up. They enter suddenly and for real into their interconnections, radiating multiple meanings, meandering loops lassoing neighboring sense and sound. They constitute new, multifacetted objects, resembling polyplanes made of mirrors. 'Beil' (hatchet) becomes 'Lieb' (Love) and 'Leib' (body), when the hurried stonehand glides over it; the wonder of it lifts us up and rides away with us on its broomstick."[5]

Many of the anagrams from *Hexentexte* reappear in altered form in *The Trumpets of Jericho*, and new anagram chains are created here as well. Most fascinatingly, however, *The Trumpets of Jericho* contains at least two embedded origin stories of Zürn's anagramming. In other words, the text offers her own account of her poetic practice independently of Bellmer, who had an agenda of his own, and who often disturbingly compared her poetry's rearrangement of language to his violent rearrangement of a girl doll's limbs in his "Doll" series. Indeed, *The Trumpets of Jericho*

contains an indirect manifesto of Zürn's poetic practice, distinct from Bellmer's mediating explanations—reason in itself for critics to pay close attention to this work.

One version of the origin story of her anagrams grows from the night of intimacies with the "little customer" in the hotel L'Esperance, site of her biographical cohabitation with Bellmer. From the start, the poetic practice connected to this tale is doomed: "O dream, you drapes, odor on you. Death struck too deeply after eighty-eight rue Mouffetard." The intimacies of this experience only make the narrator wish for a "small beautiful lady" of her own to love: "I stammer wild words in the blind hope that some day I will meet you, beautiful lady, who is much smaller than me. And if she hasn't died somewhere already, she will surely meet me. I'm yours, otherwise it will run away and mop us into death. I'm calling for you!" Yet actual memories of the time are of fear, anxiety, a consumptive illness, and codependence on a "pill-clock." By contrast, the second version of the origin story of her anagram poetry, recovered later in the narrative by digging (and dreaming) deeper beyond the first version, is rooted in childhood, and is expansive, joyful, and much richer in imagery and verse. Here is a sampling:

> Do you still remember the little girl named Ruth whom you met when you were ten? She lived in Berlin-Grünewald, in a big gray house at 2 Duncker Street. A sign hung on the garden door: Beware of the dog! Long blonde bangs hung over her forehead. She wore a very short red dress.

> Her legs were long and thin, and her knees had scabs on them because she often fell down in her wild leaps and banged her knees bloody. She would chant endless, wonderful sentences out loud, sentences that even today you haven't forgotten. How did the wizard chant go? Do you still know it? Surely you must remember it? (p. 29)

Not only is the upper-class suburb, Berlin-Grünewald, Zürn's own childhood home, but the name of this inspired childhood playmate closely echoes her own given name: Nora Berta Unika Ruth. Whether the child in question was an actual companion, an alter ego, or even a particular mood that struck from time to time, the spontaneous joy originating in language itself is vivid. It is also clearly situated in a time anterior to her encounter with Bellmer or, indeed, with Surrealism. This wordplay is rooted in the plenitude of childhood fantasy, a realm that is endangered by adult preoccupations (hence the repeated, anxious self-questioning: "Do you still know it? Surely you must remember it?"). The first anagram poetry has the quality of a magic spell, a "wizard chant," and it is recited in a kind of call-and-response exchange between an imaginary friend and a remembered self, a half-remembered, half-imagined dialogue of the selves located in a lost past.

The plenitude of this creative scene can only be recalled, not recreated; as the narrator says: "Yes, I remember everything, but I don't like to speak of it . . . She was called Ruth and she was an enchanting little creature. If things had gone right, I would have married her, but she died from a dangerous operation when

she was a young girl. I became melancholic after that and never married."(p. 30). The lost potential or "past futures" intrinsic to this scene are haunting. Unlike her other novels (*The Man of Jasmine*, *Dark Spring*) the central drama lies not in a relationship with a man, but rather within herself: the loss of an aspect of herself, "Ruth," that the female speaker of this narrative would have liked to "marry."

Attributed to the lost Ruth are some of the most energetic anagram poems of the novel, anagram poems that come close to defying translation. How is it possible to rise to the challenge of translating Surrealist anagrams into another language, one that does not have the same linguistic possibilities inherent in it as German? A brave translator might try to recreate the anagrams anew in English, finding rough equivalents and focusing on wordplay over content. This raises the obvious problem of privileging the form of Zürn's writing over the content, a choice that is already risky when dealing with self-contained poems, but which becomes prohibitively destructive when the poems are embedded in a narrative that motivates which words are chosen for manipulation and rearrangement. I have been faithful to word repetitions and word associations as much as possible, but have occasionally replaced (often imperfect) anagrams with other forms of repetition, particularly alliteration, which recombines and repeats the vocal sounds of a word rather than the alphabetic letters. My hope is that my translations faithfully preserve the feeling of the original, while (at their best) repeating the estrangement of Zürn's anagrammatic practice on linguistic meaning by

running her chants through the language-machine for one more iteration, this time between languages rather than within a single language. Surely this refracts even more visibly the "unconscious" kernel of language, the associations built up over time by cultures and revealed in poetic practice.

One example, the paradigmatic first "wizard chant" by Ruth in the narrator's childhood memory, may serve as an illustration. This chant was triggered by the arrival of a repairman to test the water usage gauge, or "Wasseruhr" in Ruth's childish terminology. Here is my translation: "The wiggle-sand grunts to Wurst-Louise: water-clock, sugar-coin, dust drips to the root. If you want it, pick it up, run to the wall and hey, ho, back again. If you want a hundred hey hos, eat wonder sugar." The original is a series of nonsense words related to almost-anagrams, words that are often one phoneme off from a more comprehensible word: "Der Wackelsand grunzt zur Wurstluise: Wasseruhren, Zuckergeld, Staub rinnt in der Wurzel. Willst du es, hebe es, rennt zur Wand er, ri und rag zurück. Wenn du hundert Ri-Rag willst, essen Zauberer Zucker." Since the chain of linguistic associations begins from a factual detail, the "Wasseruhr," I begin there, translating it literally as "water-clock," a move that curtails the possibility of making my own new anagrams in English. Content is not fungible. The chant is a series of impossible compound-nouns: wiggle-sand, Wurst-Louise, water-clock, sugar-coin. In addition to the impossible compounds, there are also independent words that look as if they should be tacked together even though they are not. "Wand er" looks similar to "Wanderer," "ri und rag zurück" looks pre-

cariously close to the more familiar "zig-zag," tic-tac. "Zauberer Zucker," "wonder sugar" (the sing-song echo of two words ending in "er" and "ar" seemed sonically appropriate), also veers off in the direction of "sauberer Zucker" ("cleaner sugar"), "Zauberer Sucher" ("magician seeker"), "Zauberer Zucker" ("wonder shudder"). The second sentence of the chant is almost entirely a set of prefixes, suffixes, short pronouns, and words that can be easily added to or separated from verbs in German—a dismantling of language that is far less orderly than a typical anagram. The "hundred hey-hos," "hundert Ri-Rag," that the unnamed second-person addressee, "you," brought into being here, may want, seems to be a fracturing and flying apart of logic-based language in favor of free-floating sounds. As a translator, my main concern is to mirror the increasing fragmentation without losing the musicality or the basic content of the original, a necessarily imperfect task that nonetheless keeps the original in view at all times instead of covering it up with sense, or with equivalent wordplay in English using different words. Across language boundaries, one sound poem echoes, or speaks to, another.

In some ways, the deeper fragmentation of language on display here is simpler to translate than the saner, more collected anagramming of Bellmer's example, the "Leib"/"Lieb"/"Beil", or "body"/"love"/"axe" anagram complex (which also surfaces at different points in this story). Like Saussure's found anagrams in Roman poets, the anagrams here are not completely perfect; they are missing certain letters and are set at odd angles to one another despite the obvious repetitions and permutations. Rather than

mathematical, they are symptoms of a traumatic perspective that Zürn is representing in language, a state of mind in which time, geography, and even the relationship of the self to itself is out of joint. The translation of that traumatic loss into language aims to recreate the plenitude that her narrator seeks in all her dreams of the past and of impossible presents. When she hesitates, it is "ink-thunder" and "word-murder" (p. 30) but when she succeeds, the result is magic, "wonder sugar." Stepping into language's unconscious is so profoundly healing, despite the inevitable depersonalization, that Zürn ends this narrative, her strongest and most assertive story, by dissolving her narrating voice into the breath of the unnamed winds surrounding her. Death of the self is no longer death, but a form of travel to somewhere new (as we discover with her, as readers). The wind's breath carries on after her breath is lost within it„whirling onward. "Round about it became evening and traveled with me, who had become a blessed child again, into the land of Howthewhere. O Winds, thousand brothers, let me pass away in your breath."

Notes

1 Mary Ann Caws, "Unica Zürn: Beyond Bizarre," in *Dark Spring* (New York: The Drawing Center, 2009), p. 41.

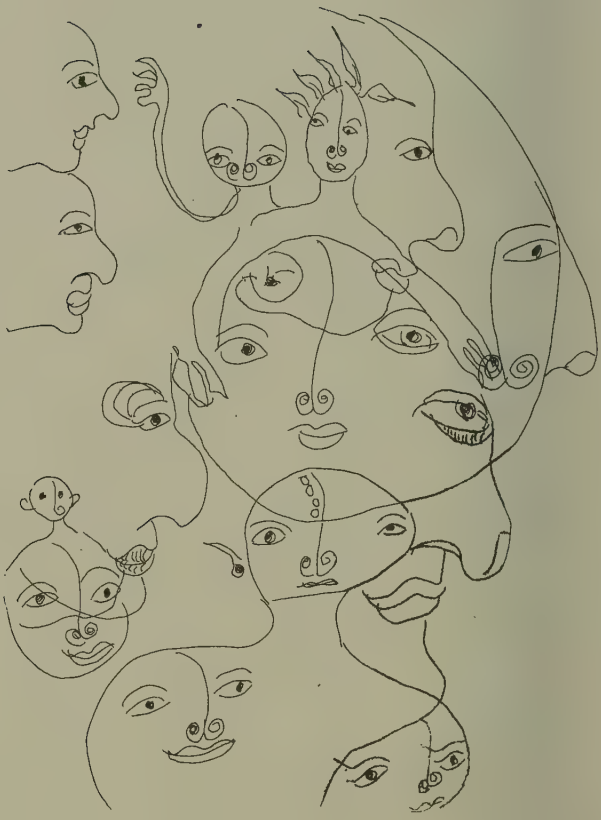
2 Friedrich Nietzsche, *The Gay Science*, trans. Josefine Nauckhoff (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2001), p. 84.

3 Taken from Pierre Joris's translation of Bellmer on Jerome Rothenburg's online blog, *Poems and Poetics*, http://poemsandpoetics.blogspot.com/2009/07/unica-zurn-nine-anagrammatic-poems.html, accessed 1 October 2014.

4 Ibid. (my edited version of Joris's translation from Bellmer).

5 Ibid.

THE TRUMPETS OF JERICHO



They've sounded nine times already, yet he still can't decide whether to come into the light of this world. For the last nine months, I've lived in a gruesome inner union with my unborn suckling infant. The big slack glistening amniotic sac burst with a loud bang on a Tuesday morning in the cold February light. Since then, he's been tearing apart the fleshy curtains of my many intestines with his tiny little red hands, hoping for a shimmer of light in his disconsolate darkness. He swims through my swollen body with the final courage of a weak swimmer who is close to drowning, gasping desperately for air like a fish that has been washed ashore. Still unborn, he already has to fight for his life. It takes from him the little strength that he possesses. But he is tougher than I had thought. Now the bastard has carved out the forbidden path to my weak heart, as if this twitching bundle of muscles were his anchor of salvation. He bores his small finger down into my heart and clings tightly to it, like a person might cling to the tautly stretched rope of his gallows. My heart is terrified by this assault and wants to stop beating. I lean very far forward, lay my mouth on my swollen belly, and shriek loudly in long, drawn-out notes to frighten my unborn suckling. The sweet days of youthful peace are over, when I was still slim and hurried with big steps from one lover to another, impatient for the biggest adventure, the adventure that didn't want to appear. Who was it, anyway,

who fathered this hateful child in the sixteenth year of my life? I've forgotten. There were too many who followed my graceful footsteps, too many who wanted to share my youthful nights, too many that I left behind, paralyzed in the hips. Didn't I forbid them all to make me with child? Now my beloved freedom, the dancing freedom of a proud young cat, is in danger, and that's why I am cool-headedly deciding that this suckling must die. I live alone in a round tower chamber. My friends are the black ravens—apart from them, I have no friends. Proud, young, independent, and a member of the Eccentric's Club, I spend my days however I like, in other words doing nothing. Lost in my wild, passionate dreams, I refuse to forgive my father for begetting me. He begat the most dismal melancholy and anger against life in me. An unconquerable inheritance. How often have I wanted to throw myself out of the tower window and into the depths. Only my unconquerable laziness stopped me. I would have had to bury myself afterwards, since I had nobody to do it for me. I hate the notion of slowly rotting in the raspberry bushes at the foot of the tower. Maybe the ravens would have been my gravediggers?—But this is not the problem that concerns me now, namely: who will free me from my unborn suckling? He doesn't seem to have any intention of leaving my body, as if he suspects the fate that awaits him. I climb for the twenty-first time onto the tall table on which my last meal still stands, and leap down onto the floor. Maybe these hard shocks will move him to finally leave my body. If I weren't so afraid of pain, I would take the sharp bread knife and use it to open my belly, so that the bastard, whom I hate with all my strength, could leave me through that hole.

A raven flew into the window and is picking at chunks of meat on the plate. Go ahead and eat in peace, good beast, I grant this to you and to me. The belltower strikes eight o'clock in the evening and the tiny little red hands of my unborn suckling are still dissecting the many beating chambers of my heart, which is stretching and compressing itself in a quiet rhythm. The weight of my unwanted suckling is monstrously heavy in my breast. If he stays that high up, maybe I can give birth to him through my mouth. I have an uncle who gave birth to his daughter through his ear at the age of sixty-six. (Such artful tricks are an idiosyncrasy of our family.) Later, I will set my uncle's story down on paper. I push out a violent cry to challenge him to climb up into my bloating distended throat. It is a monstrous torment for me that this Satan doesn't want to leave me. As if he suspected what an exquisite death I have been preparing for him. Since the first month of my pregnancy, I have been dreaming about his endlessly slow, celebratory death. He who has sucked all the strength from my flesh and bones day after day for nine months, he will die slower than a snail can move, limpingly covering a thousand-mile trail. And I will ceremonially pack his tattered, bloody remains in seven different packages and send them to my last seven lovers. Maybe he is equally the son of all seven? Since these men could only sire a single son. It will soon be night and my condition still hasn't changed. Should I stand on my head like my uncle did, to make the birth process easier for my child? I feel as if I were about to suffocate, as if he were blocking off my windpipe. My long, beautiful hair is getting damp from fear sweats. My long, noble fingers are cramping. I feel deathly terrible, as if I should die at any minute. A wild rage shakes me against the

fruit not of my womb, but now of my throat, and I would give a great deal to return to the condition of virginity.

An entire swarm of ravens forces its way through the round, open tower window, and the birds extinguish the candle-flames with their wings. The darkness does me good, as if I could better forget my humiliation in the dark. I feel a tiny hand scratching in my throat. Ha! If I only had it between my teeth, then I'd hear its bones crunching—a dulcet sound in my delicate ears. I'm carrying a child in my throat! Enigmatic situation.

Out of pride and a sense of justice, I cannot allow this hateful creature to smother me. I'd rather smother it first. I throw myself at the large plate of meat scraps and begin to gorge on the food. Then I feel with pleasure how the creature—hard-pressed—leaves my throat and slides back down into my belly. I feel a truly ravenous hunger after this long, monotonous afternoon that has cost me so much commotion, and devour the food into myself. A glorious idea brushes the harmonious coils of my fragrant brain: QUININE!

I own an entire box of quinine pills. This medicine is not just useful against malarial fevers, no, it also causes contractions in pregnant women. That's what I need, not the help of a prying doctor, since the birth of this many-fathered abomination must be kept secret. I possess a sharp and shiny pair of scissors with which I'll cut the umbilical cord. A sharp and shiny pair of scissors that will be very happy when they cut through the tiny fingers' delicate knuckles. I swallow 33 quinine tablets. That would send an overgrown ox into labor. I lay myself down in the dark on the red velvet coverlet of my bed, by the wide-open window. I wait. I wait for the

contractions, which begin suddenly, in a wave of powerful stomach cramps, as if my innermost parts were being turned inside out. I rocket up and down on my bed, as if I were lying beneath the heavy, smothering body of a giant. I want to escape these excruciating labor pains, but I can't. They grow stronger and stronger every minute. Quavering waves move my stomach, like the sea moving beneath a storm. I groan like the brittle rotting wood of an old tree in the wind. I curse the seven fathers of my son, because they are the ones to thank for my being in such pain. A bat darkens the moon in front of my window and sails into my room, soundless as a butterfly. It entangles itself with its little claws in my long, damp hair and tries vainly to free itself. I beg of you, honored bat, go land on the table, where you will find a plate of tender beef that will melt on your tongue. I honor you, you serious, uncanny night spirit, you who resemble a gray mouse with leathery wings. I will give you all I own as a present—(and that's not much). But please leave my hair, because you are bothering me during the serious business of bringing my child into the world.

Every contraction—and now they are coming in short, one-minute intervals—fuels my hate for the child. It will surely be a repulsively ugly child, since its mother hasn't granted him a single good thought during nine months in the womb. The bat, half dead from fright, has lain down on my hurting head and will hopefully fall asleep. She's no longer tearing at my scalp with her claws. She's calmed herself. But I'm in a wild spiritual uproar: I'm outraged against the pains in my belly that tear apart my spine, as if I weren't already warped enough from birth onward. I gnash my

teeth, I groan, I growl like a riled dog, but out of pride I will not scream, even though I have no neighbors who would be bothered by my howls.

The most recent of your seven fathers, my sweet little son, was as hairy as a black ape and had a snout full of rotting, black teeth. His crooked fingernails were black and long, like his hair, and they dug into my delicate shoulders when he made love to me. But he spun rich, delicate, and imaginative speeches while we rested after our embraces in his cold, barren basement room. None of your seven stinking fathers could talk as scintillatingly as he could. I won't give you any opportunity to use the speaking talent that you may have inherited from this father. My belly, with its obscene and uninhibited waves of movement, is still growing in circumference. Now it's time. I throw the coverlet off my legs in order to watch closely how you, my sweet bastard, are coming into the light of this world. I can already see your red, wrinkled forehead surfacing between my thighs. You've got a black shock of hair on your fat head. Your face is smeared with my blood. You nose is wide and flat, and your toothless mouth is wide open. You smell like the insides of my belly—a nourishing smell that seems like a meal to me. It looks insane: your head, sticking out of my lap. A thing like that should be forbidden. All births should be forbidden from today onward. All births should be punished by the death penalty. If I had any say in the matter, then there would be no more people from today onward. Only cats and, of course, me. I know that the sun loves me and can't do without me, just as I love it and can't do without it. We belong together. In the hot, still sunshine,

the beautiful time of madness comes over me that I relish like nothing else in this world.

Let me first finish with this obscene birth, and then I'll devote myself again to the beloved madness, since we're in the middle of summer. The sun is my god. The god of madness. Why can't I always live in a state of hallucination? I complain bitterly that I'm normal for the majority of the year. The sun comes so seldom to the miserable climate in which I must live. The clouds are always massing themselves together in front of her shining face; her glow is rarely unveiled completely. I hate the clouds and the rain, which weighs me down like lead and makes me shiver from cold.

I begin to pull on the head of my unwanted son. His bones are soft and it is entirely possible that he will die under my two hard hands before his body has entirely passed out of my own.

A wind picks up, howling and the bat on my head pushes out a cry of sorrow. If I rip my son's head off, I won't have helped myself at all, since the rest of his body will still be stuck inside me. My labor pains are still tremendous. The body that slowly follows the head is so misshapen that it completely tears me to pieces. I am now heaving out tremendous screams of pain. My tower room quakes from my cries. I've given birth to the ugliest child that I've ever seen. He has a hump on his left shoulder and, young as he is, he already has beard hairs growing. He has round, bulging goggle-eyes like a frog, and he shrieks as if he's about to be murdered, until he sticks his red fist into his ugly throat. He appears to have entered the world with a ravenous hunger. Relieved, I cut through the umbilical cord and am finally freed of him. I have the urge to

drown him on the spot or sit on his face and suffocate him, but I've suddenly become very tired. I hear how my abominable child sucks loudly on his fist, making smacking sounds. He seems to feel content. My breasts are hard and heavy, filled with milk. My breasts hurt, but I would rather die than let this hated bastard drink from them. He trembles from cold. Let him croak! How he must have gotten used to being warm and comfortable in my belly. Yes, my son, the world is cold and hostile. I lay him on the floor, naked as he is. Luckily he doesn't cry. If he bothered me with his cries, I would kill him right away. Black hairs are even growing out of his ears and nose. Hideous creature! The night is warm and quiet. The bat on my head has stopped moving. Maybe it died of fear. No, the night is not warm and quiet. The storm whistles around my tower, and I suddenly go cold. I crawl into bed and pull the blanket over my head. This ugly day is over. I won't even go to the effort of cutting my infant into seven pieces and packing him up in seven boxes. I won't even torture him, though I would have enjoyed it so much. Tomorrow morning I'll bury him alive. That will be simplest.

I count out loud and recite folk songs to tire myself out. I can't fall asleep. But then I fall asleep after all, and dream. I dream of two naked, ugly twin brothers who are holding themselves wrapped together at the hip, and are hopping down a mountain. They sing at the top of their lungs: wandering is the miller's joy, wandering is the miller's joy, wa-a-andering. The ground under their feet swarms with fat black toads that they stamp on with their big feet. I sleep and dream of two naked twin brothers who wade through a sea of bloody black toads and perform wild leaps.

They run into each other's big heads and tear out each other's hair. They grab each other by the folds of their hanging bellies and scratch each other's faces bloody. A butterfly of great beauty lands on one brother's shoulder. Its wings are black and red. One of the twins catches this beautiful butterfly on his brother's shoulder and crushes it in his fist. I wake up in anger over this shameful deed. The wind is still howling around my tower and the bat has abandoned my head. I listen to the rattling breath of my son, of whom, soon, I will never speak again. The rattling is sometimes broken by a deep sigh, like a sob. Should you, o Reader, recall the dreadful day or uncanny night of your own birth, then you will feel comforted when you think of the overwhelming tenderness with which your mother pressed you, freezing inhabitant of Earth, to her warm heart. Know that I would rather die than perform the slightest gesture of kindness toward my humpbacked son. If you are an empathetic person, then feel sorry for his ape's snout if you want. I don't feel sorry for him, and yet he still troubles me. I wish he would die a natural death in this night. I am too tired to climb down the 88 steps to bury him alive. I see with amazement that I am addled: I will have to bury him anyway, even if he dies a natural death. Oh, nothing is more repulsive than situations that lead to a corpse. The dead body should just dissolve into nothingness. I'm for simple solutions to problems, especially when they have to do with death. Our Earth is mucked with corpses. Soon you won't be able to find room anymore to bury a corpse, unless people begin stacking them on top of one another in mass graves. I rub my eyes with my fists to make the interior of my tower, which I have seen

too many times, vanish. The sight of the round, bare room has become tedium. When I rub my eyes with my fists, I see fantastic images: purple hallways decked with golden stars. Colorful moving serpents in a chaotic knot. A glass palace with wide steps made of snow, a rotating crown made of pearls and gemstones that casts long, glittering rays into the night. And always again that long row of purple velvet halls stitched with gold stars. Suddenly I want to take a bath and wash the blood from my thighs, but I don't move. I lie there motionless in my filth and feel sorry for myself. Today, the day I brought this ugly child into the world, I suffer more from my loneliness than on other bitter days. I cry for all the unhappiness of the world. A stream of tears overflows my face and I shake from suffering. Around the lake, the ravens talk. The roe deer and the blackbird drink tea and no mortal soul is looking after me. The raven, seer of the evening's calamity, knocks three times with his beak against my window. My heart-wrenching sobs wake me up. Finally I awaken from the frightful dream. I'm alone. Alone! I cast a mute icy gaze into the corner of the room. No monstrous son is visible there. From behind the wall, the small voice of the moment speaks to me: "Your best shot is sinking. Soon your time on Earth will be over. The finite limps quietly around the yellow corners. Soon you will lie beneath the stone and stink. Soon you will hate your life's happiness, which was your childhood." The small voice of the moment that sings every unhappiness, with the blue gaze of mute ice, will soon, very soon, fall silent. I sit in my mummy-chair and unhappiness gnaws at my leg. Happiness is a stupidity; happiness teaches me nothing, but just makes me empty. Unhappiness

fills me with clean, drunken notes like a concert. Deafening and shattering, like a long song of summer-children. I sink again into deep dreams and don't stop asking myself if I will ever meet him. I go down three paths in the rain and see his image in waking. He, the magician. A black angel that encloses me in the dragon-body. Two silver rings lie in the way, on the moist moss. Our rings, which we will never wear, since we always go past one another. You, in your country and me in my cursed gray city of rain. A long time, in the rain I'll be your . . .

I see death's hours hurrying by with bitter mouths. If only it were easy! If only it were like a big sweep that would lift me up to the stars. If only it were finally infinity, in which I would be allowed to live. Please push me, a poor dog tired of suffering, into the emptiness of the end. You are there, whom I would like to see blinded. How often has the fine nerves' dress been shredded, in the terrible impatience with which I await the end of my days. Deeper, still deeper I fall into the already sunken. Without yet having lived I will die, heirless, softly in bed, neck broken, after seven gloomy autumn weeks.

I can no longer ride in a car without thinking of crashes. The cars in my big city drive so close to one another that I think every moment that they will grate their ribs away and show their innards. They rip each other's bellies open or lose their wheels. Merely to beg and to yearn hurts. Every day, I shout: help! But no one hears me. Out of bashfulness my voice has grown too soft. Should fear be considered a good sign? It makes me sensitive. Who wouldn't want to be sensitive? I am extremely frightened of life. Should I

get a policeman drunk and steal his gun while he's sleeping? How else am I supposed to get a gun? To stick the gun's barrel in my mouth and squeeze the trigger. The burst brain paints a beautiful star on the wall.

If only it were easy. A gentle shove from the moon lifts me up into the stars. The last quick trip goes all the way up to the highest cliffs, where the eagles sit in their nests: the room of the eagles. Their chambers. I'd like to have my coffin up there, floating in outer space. The ceiling has been opened and the Poor Soul can fly out into the infinite. But she is too afraid to throw herself into death. She is a weary donkey, and lies on her hard donkey bed. She isn't dizzy when she lies down. But when she stands up, it feels to her as if the floor beneath her feet is rising up perpendicularly and she falls about as if drunk. She is already quite weak from so much lying down. She doesn't leave the house anymore. She doesn't open the window anymore. She wraps herself in blankets and freezes anyway. She has no more courage. That's the whole secret. She sews black hearts into a white cloth, under the tin shade of an old, dark, flickering lamp. A hump of snow lies in the courtyard in front of her little window. A white hillock on the black earth. It's cold, and she has no fire in the heating-stove. She is so shy that she doesn't dare ask for help. What's more, she hardly knows a single soul. The beautiful rosebushes in the garden are black and frozen. She listens to the snow. She is like me. We are both a single being.

I say meaningless little sentences out loud to quiet myself, and to numb my fear of life: the hungry duck lies captured in the fisherman's tower. The flames of her loneliness rise up. The smoke from

her candle hisses in the flames. The spirit of haste asks her at night about the well-being of her siblings in the green pond. A shy answer whispers from the folds of the curtain: they are fine, they swim and spawn ably.

The voice from the curtain says quietly, smiling: this life cannot be reality. Real life is beautiful and effortless and a great blessing. The duck in the fisherman's tower rolls onto her side in her sleep and dreams about a stunningly big question: who came into the world first? The egg or the duck? A question that can make professors of natural history blush. Yes, if you think life is bad, then just ask the duck about her own experiences: swimming all day with her belly in cold water. Try that for once, you malcontent.

Last night, nine Tartars swam across the same lake. They carefully held their heads out of the water. In their mouths, held tight between their small, pointed teeth, each of them carried a sharp knife. They are feverishly looking for nine fairies. Large rats accompany the swimmers. The Tartars want to baptize the fairies with the sour juice that flows beneath the bark of the willows, and no one knows why. When the nine Tartars swim to shore, they see a big sign sitting in the grass with the following words written on it: Do Not Step On the Grass. The Tartars, who don't like it when anyone forbids them something, step all over the soft lawn with their wide, brown feet. The big rats follow them closely and bite them in the feet. Their long, naked tails ragingly beat the grass.

A lovely little water-castle rises out of the lake. All its windows are lit, and the breeze is suddenly filled with entrancing music. The water is still and green, like moss. A llama stands on the roof of

the castle like a weathervane, turning in the wind. Its head points north. A wild date palm rips itself free of its roots and wanders slowly into the sea. The tired knives between the Tartars' teeth suddenly come alive. The knife-handles bend and buckle in a wild lust to attack. The knives leap out of the wide mouths and bury themselves in the naked breasts of the Tartars, who are surprised to death. The blood runs like silk, and slowly mixes with the semen from the ducks' love-nest. The shrieks of the Tartars meeting their deaths lures the fairies closer, and they see with satisfaction that their enemies are lying in death.

A sea of flowers grows out of the dust of this life. The mirror images of the dead Tartars slowly waft up into the dark heavens and drift away with the clouds. If you look carefully at the clouds now, after a little searching you'll be able to discern their figures. A sea of blue ibis blossoms floats on the lake. Wanderer, you who steps forward with effort amid the dust and ashes of this life, lean down to the still water and scoop a handful of blue ibis blossoms, for winter will not keep you waiting long. By doing so, you will save a small, moist scent of summer for yourself during the cold time, which lasts seven months here. A scent of summer, which you love as I do. Now are the long bright days in which so much might happen, if that which we wish for ourselves would only occur. No one knows that. Oh, how good it is. A black thing on the tree bough moves in the wind. Below stand five guards who watch the violently hanged man. The guards are wounded by weariness, but they don't dare sleep. Why not? The hanged man is dead and long cold. They are watching so that another man, sorrowed to

death, doesn't come along and hang himself on the black bough of the same tree. For the whole land is flooded with a large and powerful wave of the deepest melancholy, and wherever anyone goes or stands, they think here of violent death. Even the little children lean over the deep water, ready to sink down into it. In the guardsmen's old hut, the wall tilts and the beams are cracking. There is a poor orphan who hanged herself from the roof, and her swinging body hits against the timbered wall. The orphan was tired of life, and wanted to bury herself on her own, beneath the soon-to-collapse wooden house. The maid had put sharp stones in her bed and had slit open the feather mattresses with a knife. In these hostile circumstances, the orphan had lost all will to live. She waited with the patience of an angel for the moment when the fragile hut would collapse. She lost her parents, who were always dressed in black, when she was three years old. They left her nothing but a black goat, a white featherbed, and the spiteful maid who made her life hell and sprinkled sand and too much salt into the soup.

Weighed down by overwhelming fatigue, the guardsmen fall asleep beneath the hanged man's tree and the orphan is buffeted even more strongly against the hut's roof, and a groaning and quaking moves through the walls' rotten wood. The maid has hurried far away to the dance square of the neighboring village and is in the midst of sprinkling grated glass in her bridegroom's beer. If she couldn't scatter misfortune somewhere, the maid would die. There will be several more deaths in this mild May night, even though the endlessly bewildered government has forbidden

suicide, on pain of death. Oh, how good that no one sees how the hut is just about to collapse on the poor orphan. The goat spends nights in the meadow, and when the orphan is dead, no one will come to milk her and she will have terrible pains in her swollen udder, just like I did in my swollen breasts in that hideous dream in which I gave birth to my son.

In a distant, sunny land by the seashore, where yellow egg-sand was mixed with sweet rock sugar, lived a small child who played with seashells and colored stones. The child never wanted the No. It opened its heart to the great Yes-saying and was full of trust. It often looked over its shoulder and asked the murmuring, the breathless nothingness of the warm air: "Is the whole world beautiful? Is it this small?" The sun was cold. A light breeze wafted over the sea. A gush of gray whale-eggs streamed out of a giant whale. The blue of the sky was like silk, and waved to the child. When the child laid its ear to the wall in its bedroom, it could hear the water trickling inside. It made a gentle music, like a lullaby. The child saw a chest swimming on the water, a chest that wanted with all its might to get to shore. Maybe it was full of toys, or maybe there were only torn-up old stockings inside. The child had already learned from experience that one should not have very high expectations if one didn't want to be disappointed. But what could be in the chest? Before it had time to look, the bedsheet rolled itself up around the child and transported it to another country, a country that had been called since time immemorial the land of Howthewhere. There, the world seemed much bigger when

one looked over one's shoulder at it. There were people there with wilting and blooming noses. You could read the seasons from the people's noses. The cows could make themselves small like a fist in order to creep back into the cheese made from their milk. It was a complicated process, and they could do nothing about it. It was their fate to only exist as cows for a very short while. Here, there were stones that rolled off into the horizon without anyone pushing them. The land was covered with rolling stones, which was sometimes dangerous if you stood in their way: they rolled right over you and onward, and you were flat as a bug afterward. Out of a fear of ending up underneath the stones, the people here swayed as they walked like ships in a storm. Dark thoughts swirled down from above and sank into their foreheads, heavy as a drop of lead falling into water. The child was afraid of these perpetually fearful and sorrowful adults in this rolling land, and longed to return to the place of its birth, to the warm beach where yellow eggs, as countless as grains of sand, rolled like waves into mountains of white rock sugar. A beautiful, constant, flowing movement, the sight of which filled the child with joy. But the child's legs had already grown weak from the monotonous cheese diet and were as thin as threads of wool. They buckled under his body when he began to make his way back to his old land. No toil or trouble could save it. It had to stay in the cursed land of rolling stones and eternal cheese smells. Its only refuge was a pillow that a merciful man, whose nose resembled a wilted oak branch, had given him. The child's head was heavy with yearning thoughts and reeled tiredly

back and forth on his thin neck. This child did not grow old, in spite of his soft pillow. It died young from cheese sickness, a painful and foul-smelling death that often befell strangers in this land.

Three-and-a-half ghosts of unknown origin, transparent as glass, gnaw with pointed teeth on the dry green wood of my six window shutters, arranged in a circle. The ghosts gnaw hotly in the wind. Do they want to scare me until I reveal the big secret from my beautiful childhood? The dry green wood crunches softly under their hurried teeth. They are holding each other's see-through hands and are chasing around my tower in an endless game of ring-around-the-rosy. In high, thin voices, they sing an endless and difficult-to-understand song whose words I have learned by heart during the night because they repeated it so often: "We ghosts gnaw hotly in the wind, You will tell us your secret, You will run in the gates, You in the hate, You in the wind. Climb into the rain. Wait while you go. Pour yourself into the blue miracle of the day. Your master Isis's poor dog hung on a branch. There he dances, as if it were a mast. Rock the graybeard, hush, hush. Dog on the branch, rock the graybeard into the wonder-thing. Let it be day, home in a winter-shirt. The icy sow walked next to the tiger in the wind. My hare, you sing, so that he hung in the tree like a ghost. Mouth, open up wide and tell us the secret of your childhood." From the twelfth hour of night until the first hour of the morning, the three ghosts floated around my tower and sang in endlessly fine and high voices the song written down above, which doesn't exactly count as high poetic art, and that some will understand only after they have read it three times in a row. They were cooing

ghosts who only end their dove song when the stars grow pale and begin to fade away. They only stop cooing when the hen rises from its roost and lays its first egg of the morning, with much clucking. They only stop gnawing and humming when the rye auntie crackles in the morning fog. Cooing ghosts, the hen is coming. Disappear from my tower. Everything grows still. I open my window, and the shining morning star comes in to me. It makes in a festive round and touches my forehead and my hands and my knees and my feet with its pale light. It mutters that it should disappear to make room for the Sun. The day promises to grow hot. Seeds of madness—(a strange illness of summer plants) circle outside and touch everything green with their poisonous breath. The seeds of madness bend the gorse into crooked shapes, until it lies flat on the dry earth and can't rise up again anymore—a sad sight! O duck, hurry away from here, the rye auntie is crackling again and that means a second great disaster. Whether it's summer or winter, the disaster clings doggedly to everything that's alive. I even think there might be war. And then everything, everything will take a turn for the worse.

My ugly city lives on daybed-squabbling. The heavy shapeless lead vases of the Vatican bedew the bordellos so that the joy girls run shrieking into the streets. A new law to which everyone is subject forbids praying. Cats have recently been prohibited from posting bills. Is this life made of balm? No! This life consists of a shivering, spitting chain of stink-rats. Do you know the slut-father? He's laden with brooms and sweeps up abortions. He's pale and shakes from the strain of keeping his head above the vomit. The

slut-father is the father of the rye auntie. What a pretty family! He has a mania for forbidding all forms of pleasure. He is our worthy mayor. You can see what rabble gets pride of place and honors in our town. He allows the trumpets of Jericho to be blown three times every month and enjoys it when people quake in fear and believe the world is ending. A large rainbow encircles his golden strangling chair. Thunder and lightning surround his throne. We are howling worms at his feet. He is the hated tyrant and immeasurably rich. Nonetheless, he sweeps up abortions. He scoops gold out of citizens' pockets and believes he will have to suffer death by starvation. Some say that he is insane, which I would like to believe. But just wait, slut-father. Your downfall on the level of our city is nigh. Weapon-lice are beginning to stream through all the streets. The population arms itself secretly. Even if some say he is invulnerable, others have heard that there is a spot the size of a penny on top of his right nipple that would be very sensitive to a well-aimed dagger thrust. But it's uncanny to see how much fear the inhabitants have of the slut-father. He's been in power too long.

Once we have him pressed up against the wall, he will try to bolt away like an awkward lamb. He has been preaching for years to us in praise of usefulness, even though every reasonable person knows that usefulness is the root of all sins.

Once we have finally overpowered him—(since he is immeasurably strong), only then will his shroud, made from old tinsel, begin to sing from worry: "O death, you undiscovered continent, my master is freezing cold as a corpse. All time is all beginning. Usefulness is a vice."

Then it will be too late for the slut-father.
He will die. Arrogant and icy. Patience!

Once upon a time there was little warm iron all alone. This was so long ago that hardly anyone can still remember. It was heated by the Sun and glowed on hot days. Don't make any noise and don't drink any wine, because that disturbs the warm little iron. Because there was no ice just then, the blackbird carnation ran softly along the lake into a seed-egg. All the ducks waved and called out, "Travel like that seed-sperm into a warm and dark belly. Sink into it, water kernel, sink into a soft pillow and wait for your festive birth. You will have a proud white feathered throat and two white wings, but you'll be yellow at birth like an egg yolk. You won't eat any hard red carrots, just soft green plants that swim in water. You'll become a beautiful big duck and when you're unlucky, a hunter will shoot you in the fall while you're flying over the water. Your white feathered throat will be plucked and you'll simmer in the pan."

How is it that I think about death so much, violent death? I urge out of love, because magic pays off and love is a great magic, terrible and deeply serious. The bitterly downturned corners of your mouth lift themselves into a smile when you love. Ivy, that deadly plant, is transformed near your mouth into roses and white lilies when you love. Your blue eyes begin to gleam as blue as the stone in my old ring when you love. And for one small, joyful moment you finally lose your great fear.

And you drink the raven's wine of lust with your eternally

young girlfriend, to whom you remain faithful until your death. The two of you live happily ever after until you draw your last breath in your wild madman's garret and surprise yourself with wonderful wiles and stratagems that allow you to forget aging and back pains. In the twilight of a long, light summer you two will invent tender games and delicate sins. Doves come with the evening dew and fly into your windows. Your little beloved shows you her bosom ornament. You are delighted, as if drunk with blessedness. The azure of the heavens is perfect, beautiful. A thousand spells fill the warm still night. You drink in the magic tea with your kisses. You lie in your soft featherbeds as if in the arms of the warm summer breezes, and icy evenings are so far away and forgotten. Right up until the morning fog rolls in, you spend your time in long, confidential conversations: "O you, my brother of the windmills, you rest in the morning's wind. No one else has confided in me yet as much as you do. Your voice murmurs in my ear like a small, warm swarm of bees. And no bee from your many words stings me. Your words flow like honey into my heart. O dream, you drapes, odor on you, if only death won't strike us now. One of the rarest moments of well-being is in us. O no, not death, in this unforgettable night of intimacies."

The moon emerges. "I give up," cries the woman, whose thoughts are taking other paths from his, since she is fearful by nature. Doesn't she have any real faith in her love? She calls out, "I give up." Alas, pitiful violations, the smell of the eighty apes. O dream, you drapes, odor on you. Death struck too deeply after eighty-eight rue Mouffetard. A long time has gone by since we lived in those two little rooms, in the Hotel de L'Esperance, Rooms

42 and 44, and you cooked mussels with white wine and pepper. You, the black baron, and me, the sweet scoundrel. Death, blow it into the snow, until big letters begin to form and people can read it white-on-white: life is beautiful, so is seeming, o, even damage is beautiful. To love life, ach, laughing need. Life bites into your lap. The sun is beautiful and melts ice. Even the cold hard ice seems to gain life from how much we love each other. I warm the cold, lonely, hard iron with my joy-drunk body. All fear is forgotten. I have confidence in life again. What a strange wonder! Hadn't I laid myself out already in preparation for death? Life is sublime. My courage is new and unaccustomed. Do I dream? Have I changed so much? And why?

The little customer of the Hotel de L'Esperance is pale and tired. "I'm tired," says the little customer. "I'm small and tired and when I cough, I spit up blood. I have a fever. I am tired of the pomp of this powerful city of Paris. Give the red alarm light to my corpses, says Death. O my panic brothers, I cry out in the dust of thorns. There comes a giant toad creeping toward me and spins me into its net. I breathe the silver threads of the web into my poor lungs and afterward my chest is no longer quite so oppressed and painful. My pill-clock speaks to me at night: wake up, little customer, take medicine number 3 for your poor bleeding lungs. And in the morning at half past four my pill-clock wakes me again: wake up, do you still have any water in your glass? It's time for you to take your medicine number 7.

And the little customer coughs and spits blood into his reddened handkerchief. "I hear my panic brothers coughing in every country," thinks the little customer, while he leans his aching back

against the pillows. "In the morning when I get up, my chest hurts so much. I pour water into my cupped hand and inhale it into my nose. It runs down the back of my throat and I spit it out again from my mouth. In my village, which lies high in the mountains, people say that you can cure yourself of tuberculosis in this way. I do these exercises every morning with cold water, but I don't have the impression that they are helping me. I, the little customer, am very tired. I will go far away to look for my longing. As far as the hen must go who pecks at stars as if they were grains of barley. Until the fox catches it and bites through its narrow neck. I cough, I cough. Worry breaks my door in two. I am so little because I have such short legs. My upper torso is long, with broad shoulders. When I sit, I'm a handsome man. But I have been condemned to loneliness. My kisses mean death for a woman; she would become as sick as I am. On top of that, it's hard for a small man to find a woman. I cough, I cough!

Tonight, during the short break that my pill-clock allows me for sleep, I dreamed that I was Prince of the Sea. Normal-sized, with an enticing smile. I lived in a palace with magnificent rooms, in the company of two silken goats. Prince of the Sea, you smile enticingly. Show me how you bewilder the two silken goats' magnificent rooms. Four pearl signs in gold, as if to adorn death itself. Pearl twig among the violet seeds, pearl cinnamon in the woods of Venus. Adornment, I hesitate to cleave you. Forty rooms in my palace. Forty empty rooms. Keep on turning, effervescing in a sea of salt. Show the way to wiser rooms, death. Pain, I give up. Pearl to pearl. The twittering-rooms of my palace are filled with summer

birds. I had every reason to be happy. Didn't I have a beautiful dream in this night? In the cruelly short time during which my pill-clock lets me sleep. I cough, I cough. Soon I will be no more than a tired shadow in the great beyond . . . and yet! I wish I had a beautiful lady, much smaller than myself, whom I could carry in my arms to my sick-bed. Always alone and shut off from love, I too would like once, on a warm fruit night, to love a small beautiful lady. Even if you still haven't appeared yet, I still want to say now, with trembling lips: I am yours, otherwise happiness will run away and hard fate will throw us into loveless death. Sing, burn, Sun, don't die . . . I stammer wild words in the blind hope that some day I will meet you, beautiful lady, who is much smaller than me. And if she hasn't died somewhere already, she will surely meet me. I'm yours, otherwise it will run away and mop us into death. I'm calling for you! I need you so much! Sing, burn, Sun, don't die! Don't let it get dark around me! Sing, turn, and be born, to turn and into nothingness is never! I stammer out senseless words. Help, Heaven! I'm sinking into darkness! The clear thoughts are fading from me . . . disappearance gives meaning or they have not died and if and if dead then they were never born.

Forty-two empty rooms in the Hotel de L'Esperance. Doesn't anyone want to live here anymore? Are you all so afraid of the little customer addicted to disappearing? All the doors are closed. It is dead still in the Hotel. Rats come out of the cellar at night and rummage through the garbage cans. Doesn't anyone want to live with me anymore? No answer. All is still in the house. Not a soul. I cough, I cough. I am afraid in the empty house. One guest

after another has moved out. I'll get myself drunk now, and I won't swallow any more pills in the night. It's enough to make you lose your mind. My existence is a naked irony. If I were a poet, I would describe my outrage at life with living, hand-wringing words. But I barely learned to write my name. I should shuffle my cards of destiny again and build a fragile house of cards. When my poisonous breath touches it, it will collapse.

The clouds today look like indecent bodies in impossible entanglements. Even the images of clouds are as if poisoned by my longing imagination. I sit silently on my chair and wiggle my beautiful head. I am 42 years old and already have the appearance of a crone. The dark window wants ice and is still as darkness. It is my death party. The still water in the courtyard fountain is deep and black. A big rat stretches its gray throat out to drink. My shoes and stockings are torn. My shirt is a dirty rag. I am going to seed, I am in tatters. I don't wash myself or comb my hair anymore. Pain plucks a shriek from my breast. Ringing ore and sounding rings drone in my ears. A delicate thought on the beliefs of my childhood wants to push its way into my bleak, angry heart. I curse everything that once was holy to me.

Shrilling, the holy oil's thunder ignites hissing loins' lust. I mockingly play skittles with the money of devout foundations. Flames, lick the nuns' bottoms. You, Pastor Donkeyhero, pickle the fat souls in sugar. Death, send money, you've fattened yourself enough on the wealthy. Heathen-money-stiletto to the miserable Sun—grilled missionaries! My smarting breast drones with ringing ore and sounding rings. I have never had love in me. I am one

of the poorest, the most forgotten under the Sun. Each day there are twenty deaths under the wheels. Should I throw myself under a bus? I can just as well stay where I am. My moon already goes gray in horror there in the starless sky. Now, red bugs, hunt Anna the whore for murder. Trembling tones, weave the death dance once more in a sweet spring rondo of life. A black mouth presses against the bars in front of my window. A mouth as black as the moor. It opens and gasps for air. It is Anna Tommz, the black whore. The only woman who has ever shared my bed with me. Her eyes glow with the rage of the hunt. It's not yet night, and she's already on the street. O, just talk, Anni Tommz makes every man pull down his pants. Every night, twenty men under Anna's thin breasts. Her long bones have rubbed me raw. But Anna was the only one unafraid of my kisses.

Turn away from the sad figure of the little customer. He's gone into his lamentations and won't stop for hours. Before eight days are past, he will suffer a hemorrhage and will most likely die. Because there won't be anyone there to bury him, the rats will slowly eat him up. And because no one throws garbage into the Hotel's trashcans anymore, after the rats finish their corpse dinner, they will gradually, one after another, leave the Hotel.

Lost, long lost desire for gold. Silver, ivory, and pearls and ebony are all nobler than gold. And so many eyes that obstinately turn toward the gold over and over again. So many eyes—mad, raging lust to kill.

That's how it is! The magenta of ice is my dream. Burning sinks into coolness. Red and white mix together. Eyes, days, doors,

the old land. Your thousand-day-old eagle eyes look at me regally. First was the gaze, then the days passed, slowly—endlessly slowly in urgent, trembling waiting. Then, finally, the door opened and with it, the arms.

They sink mutely onto one another's breast. Only around the dead couple does the infinite poppy of deepest sleep drip. Eagles from their dreams trumpet the song of love. O North Star in the sea's sands, you grow pale in the early nearness of the morning sun. In the dead couple's dream-red salon, hundreds of trumpets blaze in a heart-wrenching chorale: wake up. Turn back! But the deeply sunken lids no longer lift from the dull eyes.

Sink into ashes, before the picture of silence, soon I must go. Let the stillness ring into the pale water: I am you. Don't get lost in your feelings; this is beginning to sound embarrassing. Think about your childhood, when you wanted to die from laughing. That is a long time ago. Fifty years have gone by since then, since you last laughed full-heartedly. It was when you were small. You laughed with an open mouth and flashing teeth. Sometimes your laughter capsized into tears. You were a little hysterical as a child and tended to exaggerate. Can't you remember anymore what you used to laugh about? No, you can't. If you laugh today, like an old man, which hardly ever happens, your eyes remain sad and you squeeze out an embarrassed chuckle that no one would mistake for a laugh. You're ashamed to laugh and you ask desperately: what did I laugh about so heartily as a child? You can remember almost everything related to your childhood. Your childhood was like a big, wonderful garden with labyrinthine paths and secret, hidden

bushes in which you would hide, and a hill on which a run-down summerhouse stood. But don't tell me about it. Keep those beautiful memories for yourself. No one else can participate in them as much as you and you know that you were not given the gift of vivid description. Your speech is poor and without shine. You stroll about your childhood home every day in your thoughts, from the cellar to the attic. Do you still remember the little girl named Ruth whom you met when you were ten? She lived in Berlin-Grünewald, in a big gray house at 2 Duncker Street. A sign hung on the garden door: Beware of the dog! Long blonde bangs hung over her forehead. She wore a very short red dress. Her legs were long and thin, and her knees had scabs on them because she often fell down in her wild leaps and banged her knees bloody. She would chant endless, wonderful sentences out loud, sentences that even today you haven't forgotten. How did the wizard chant go? Do you still know it? Surely you must remember it? There was something in it about the "water-clock" that was kept down below in her cellar. At least, that's what she called it. Once a month, in the morning, a man wearing a blue peaked cap would come to read the water usage from the water-clock. Then he would write down the water bill, moistening the pen with his lips.

In her bright voice, so fast you could hardly follow what she said, she would recite out loud the poem that she had made up. While doing it, she would stand on one leg and tilt her head to one side like a stork. "Run by! The wiggle-sand grunts to Wurst-Louise: water-clock, sugar-coin, dust drips to the root. If you want it, pick it up, run to the wall and hey, ho, back again. If you want a hundred

hey hos, eat wonder sugar." Then she'd shake her head so that her long hair would fly about and sing while hopping on one foot in a circle: "Three in three, egg in thee, three and three, egg in thee!"

Yes, I remember everything, but I don't like to speak of it. It just makes me sad to think back to that happy time. I've earned my peace. I have laid myself down to rest. I don't want any more excitement. She was called Ruth and she was an enchanting little creature. If things had gone right, I would have married her, but she died from a dangerous operation when she was a young girl. I became melancholic after that and never married. My head is heavy from memories, as if a thick black curtain has just been lowered. Now its musing eye is seeking me as a goal. My days are short and they sink quickly into the ice. Without ambition I would learn how to be silent now. The addiction to recording my memories has only given rise to stupid, heavy ink-thunder and word-murder. Where are the many letters that I wrote to Ruth as a child? What remains of that love? A small, touching childish poem. And a house at 2 Duncker Street that was not destroyed by the bombings. There is snow on the ground. It gleams in the sand, by the dew and the seeds. Seven eyes suck silk, fog, ink, foam. A tired goose defoliates itself. Just like how I soon will be relieved of my clothing. The winters always follow faster upon one another. Time storms hurriedly away and I don't want to follow it anymore. Stars sink and in the meantime drunken toads eat and drink my thinking-stone. Stars are nests of light and sink into the nest. As a child, I was given to reconnoitering, recognizing. Now I have been led for years by gloom into the blackness. Do you know it? Pairs

of eyes dead full of time look earnestly across the border between being and nothingness. I saw the blackbird full of thorn-bites and the faded rose full of sand in the blind sea. The moss picture left in misery, the song full of malicious significance. I saw sand full of sand and the blind roses in the lake. I've lost a friend, a big tiger cat: Heinrich!

When I returned home after a long absence, he was waiting for me on the street in deep snow, and proudly led me to our house. When I picked him up, he put his arms around my neck and pressed his head into my face. He always went out at night. In the morning, he would always come back and drink warm milk with bits of toast broken into it. Maybe a big dog hunted him down and killed him? Or he was shot while out on the prowl? He liked to go into the woods. Or maybe he was caught in a trap set by a hunter? I can't stop asking myself what happened to him. All that I can say for sure is that he wasn't there when I opened the door one winter morning. The uncertainty of his fate tortures me afresh each day. Back then, there were black and spotted dogs in the village that chased the cats and many hunters in the woods throughout autumn and winter. People would set their dogs on the cats. Was my Heinrich killed by a dog, even though he could run so fast? Did he get caught in a trap in the woods and die in fearful torment after many days of painful captivity? Did the hunters shoot him? Questions without end. What's certain is that his death was terrible and these thoughts steal my peace of mind. Where is the wisdom that sometimes accompanies the death of living creatures? Love, ravens, longing, death: sense breaks on insane emptinesses. O

nearby dust, O you fogs. Shudders that break the nonsense. Secret laughter amid tears and remorse because one dared to laugh, after such a long time of mute pain.

Tristan next to Isolde. Bitter smoke strays over harsh life. Larks build their nest in the already pale pear of a hand as red as a star. Yet it snows red, vine-red valerian-peace. Give me peace at last, my tired heart. So rest now, poor pendulum, murder-taut leather sinew, o traces on the poor throat. Psalm-oil of peace at alarm's ear. O miserable raging of pulses. O poor swaying blade at the hells' primal pass. When will you stop frightening yourself? When will peace come? And a loud, mocking voice shrieks out the answer. Peace will never come, not before you've kicked the bucket. And then it will be too late. Then you won't feel the peacefulness anymore. The situation may still change, but unfortunately I have to tell you that right now you are in the dark, cold valley of a giant black Moloch who is waiting to tear you to pieces with his 333 teeth and his sharp claws. You have no luck in your life. You were born under an evil star. The Moloch has long ears, the better to hear you with when you scream in fear. He ridicules God, whom he calls the universe's bloody fool. The Moloch smolders with bloodlust. His tail writhes in silky snakelike movements and ends in a red dagger. All the peaceful animals in the valley are alarmed, and on the watch. They are searching for a safe shelter, which they scarcely find. Don't let your candle go out tonight. The Moloch loves the darkness so he can attack his victims. By day, he can't threaten you. He knows how to make himself as small as a louse. From today onward, you will have to withhold the blessing

of nightly sleep from yourself if you want to get away with your life. Sleep as much as you like during the day. Are you afraid? Have I achieved what I wanted? You'll believe any stupid thing! The Moloch is no longer alive. He died at the grand old age of 98. Don't you read the newspaper? Someone stuffed him and now he is exhibited in a museum. Anyone can visit him for a few coins. By the way, he wasn't the only Moloch in existence. The Moloch multiplied himself as often as rabbits. And each specimen is always bigger and more dangerous than the last. Are you *thoroughly bored* by my story? I promise you, I'm as bored as you are while I'm writing this. If you scratch your head right now, you might catch the Moloch under your fingernail. A black dot, a little piece of crud. And so one boring sentence adds itself onto the next, and soon a yawningly boring page is filled. Let's do something else. Let's strike up moor-song to bring ourselves to other thoughts, noble, sublime thoughts, full of incomprehensible poetry and above all without the slightest trace of alleviating humor. We want to be dead-serious now. I lack humor, irony, these masterpieces of poetic art. So let's stride into new sorrow. Let's intone the moor-songs and strew golden earth on the coffin. The rose lay buckled on the sword that stood so forlorn in the grass of the wasteland. O earth, the rain, the algae and the moss are my witnesses that I have once again written three new, undying lines of verse. If I didn't have love, I would be a resounding ore and a ringing bell. I don't have it! Love weeps in the roof under a wax candle. It waxes in the light and the wind at night. It watches in the soft picture of You, it sobs in the ice of Never. I don't know how one makes love. But I know how

to make lust. Lust is made, I know, in the wakeful You, O, it swells like silk. I want her as if mute. Deathly wakeful, you swim, like me, into outer space. O vastness! How long the Sun shines this evening. We are at the high point of the year. The shortest nights and the longest days.

Good evening, sir, how do you do? And the melancholy gentleman answers: Going home to the grave, since the rain is blowing today. Good evening, my child, how are you?

Thank you, how healthy. I'm going to my bed. And I dare to ask a new question, close to my heart: Good evening, my sorrow, how are you? And sorrow answers me in a deep, sad voice: I'm bowling in you for the constant bend. It is right. I no longer stop bowing to my sorrow.

To wrap up any nosy questions: Good evening, my joy, how are you? The answer is worthy of my joy's stupidity: I'm fine like the good clucking hens in beer. What baked back-nonsense!

I stir six eggs, flour, sugar, and a knife's tip of salt into a hornets' dough and attempt to make raven-cakes from it, since Easter is coming soon, if it isn't over already.

I hear, say, am a back-nonsense. When quiet dreams approach, I sketch it home in the heart. I hear my ancestors cough. Two gray pike-fish sew two rings out of mummies. In my heart, an eye is growing.

That's a poem, made, from joy, on the birth of a little black cat. The cat was born in the bed of the black Baron, who felt very honored by this circumstance. The bed is his refuge from life.

Shadows of love's-blood, feather-mouth, time, charm his bed full of fish. The hour, fled from the fog in the cinnamon bath. Verse You, living thusly, dissolving into the dew of bedsheets.

The mother-cat left behind two large flecks of blood in the black Baron's bedsheets after the birth, and he refused to allow the blood to be washed out because he loved the cats so much. That is what is meant here by "love's-blood." For those who love, time is the bread on which they feed. And that, o forbidden hearts, that is in me, far from death, scattered in the wind. You see, reader, that I cannot bend my thoughts away from death, but when death actually comes to me, then I will lie whimpering with my nose in the dust. Scattered by death into the wind. His hair sieve, that is the time. Bread, from which we feed ourselves. House in the middle, destroy the woman. Through the inner waiting within yourself, you hear time, until time becomes the bread from which the loving feed themselves.

The love-leg bites into the fire. The egg remains the egg and the duck remains the duck in the fisherman's tower. A free fish jumps out of the water and would like to be grilled. Here, there is no lack of good things to eat. The animals offer themselves up to be killed and turned into dishes. How embarrassing, this crude lie! Animals have the same fear of death as people.

How many animals are killed daily on Earth, to fill the paunch of humans? Incredible numbers! Do you like this Earth? Do you like this garden?

Ghost-Count of the linden tree, old lunatic figure. The long feather is the finger that grazes all the days. The vulture falls, your tiger falls. Earth lies in the earth. Moth, tell me, does this garden on Earth please you? The day is peaceless. For a long time, the trap stares at the three strong poisons. Riddle-garland of the gallows. Does the noble animal freeze? The ice-moth gnaws the fresh green wood of my shutters. The hedgehog climbed into the air. The eagle fell out of the air. "Garden, it's raining," cooed the trap.

May your streets be quiet, purple death's maw. Everything from this journey thaws like that, trace by trace. Thirst, your fare is so poor. Tepid pulse pump whirrs: you, he it, of ice. Red is all mad play. Dreams are your fun and games. O you desire, spew everything indigestible far away from yourself. Your dreams are made of purple. Allow yourself to fare well on Earth. The music box of mourning plays the corpse song. Then we are cold. It's August 1960 and we're in Palavas-les-flots. To be exact: it's 18 August 1960. There's a fog over the sea, but the sun of hope waits behind the fog. Do you believe in me? Sing, you dream, live, live in the grayness. Hours and dust, sea urchin and leaves, climb my belief. Starting in the bloom of gray August, which builds for a rain-song in the fog, dread beloved, believe in me.

Two swimmers are lost in the tall waves, and their strength has left them. Two rescue boats ride on the sea to save them. Too late! They recover two dead. The sea rocked them for a long time, and then lost its patience. The sea washes out their mouths. It was a father and son. Their death-phantom whimpers. The sorrow-swath is there. If one can do without them? If they'll be bewept?

If someone will get sick of his tears? They were not granted dying with a warm pillow at their back. The sea eagle ascends in the fog. He loses a white feather, which slowly sinks into the water. The morning is fresh. The nobleman grabs himself by the gullet and wants to strangle himself. But when he no longer has any breath left, he lets go of his neck. It would be better for him if he died in a duel fought for the sake of a beautiful lady. The nobleman dreads life and dreads death. He doesn't know where he belongs anymore.

Dew lies on the ground. The fire stirs, crackling in the chimney. The cliff, upon which a castle stands, is encircled by the rustle of windswept branches. The nobleman grows thirsty. Thirst stirs in him like the feathers of the sea eagle. The nobleman, who has nothing noble about him, just a stupid and haughty face, a fat belly, and sagging shoulders, gets drunk on his thirst until he sinks senseless into his chair. This is not the first time it happens. Without even a drop of alcohol he gets drunk on his thirst and falls grunting from his chair. He feels as if he had died. He has achieved what he wanted. The imaginary bottle flies into the fire of the chimney-place and the glass becomes ash. The nobleman's fat legs twitch in his sleep. He dreams of a rowing sow catching fish. Above this scene, the white sea eagle in the sky snarls: hit the oars, fat sow, the dragon should seal the woman firmly, and unfurl the sail starboard. Turn back to your pigsty. And the day of shudders slowly flows downhill. The sow turns into a woman whose face the nobleman tries to read. The sow-turned-into-a-woman speaks the following remarkable words in a high-pitched voice:

"May the day of shudders flow away. Read the face of the woman, dew rises from the bottle, noble grass-dew of the sea, ach, three of the days are monotony."

The feathers rustle, sleep is over. The cliff refreshes nobility of the eye. I greet the old one, the feather, the moth, the boundary between dread and pleasure, and the spirit of the bottle from the fairy tale of One Thousand and One Nights. The spirit grows and grows if one has opened the bottle even once.

Lazy poets say: it, of . . . compose it from the soul. Count Fearcoffin, suffer it, the grass of silk. Plait the woman a bed of rushes. Ash Wednesday's hussy waits at the next corner. It, of, it of, lazy poet, tell the woman poems. And the poet answered in a deep voice: "Fly, my narrow room, the fog sweeps icily in the tea. You unfiddle the elf in the bosom. Find, incline, beloved Muse, the bloody end cowardly in the sea. The lying limbs go stiffly around in circles. Take the rapier firmly in your hand, for the witch has dribbled poison in the broomstick. She is sweeping a blessing around the holy ones."

Whomever you do not touch, in your room, it so happens that a little mouse slips in under the door. Recently two little mice even came into your room. Lay out bread and cheese for them and they will grow accustomed to your room and always return. And the siskin will sing and build its nest over your window. Everything is arranged in the best way and you're going on a trip. You leave a big piece of bread and a round cheese in your room, so that the two mice have something to eat. You often think about them while on your trip and are certain you'll find them again when you return.

But you don't see a wink of them. You look for them and find them in a tin water pitcher. O no, they weren't drowned, because there was no water in the pitcher. You find them dead in the water pitcher, much smaller than during their lifetime and totally dried out. How to explain that? They enjoyed themselves in the room, they leapt around, they climbed up to the rim of the pitcher, and they fell down inside it. They jumped up on the steep walls, trying to find an escape, trying to find an escape, and over and over again they slid back down into the pitcher. Like lunatics they ran around inside the pitcher in circles for days until they died of hunger and thirst. Now you can wait a long time before another mouse comes into your room. Who knows if a third mouse wasn't a witness of the drama, and spread the terrible story among all the other mice. You wait in vain for a new mouse. Maybe the mice think you set a trap for them on purpose with the pitcher?

And what will happen next September? Will you still be waiting? Wasps speak in the nest on the roof. Die, be thrifty, woman, in the nest. Don't speak, send yourself. You should always build the nest in the latest and never stop living in anticipation until he relaxes you with warmth in the dark sea of expectation, always—late—with him. The lark over the field has sung. The sparrowhawk's power is your meadow-seeds. Even in winter the hungry birds find something, even if they pick kernels from the frost-stiff mosses. And what will happen in November? In November we will be the bound ones, the brothers of the coming cold. We are bound, the M wounded in the O. The I in the O will hum past and the S (Silence) will be in the mouth before evening. Water will swallow the

stone. No matter how arrogant and cold it lies there in its whole, hard, magnificence. Island, seek out the water, says the wind. Row westward, mop the deck, listen, as its speech diminishes, rip a leak in the deck. Rage ticks into the water. Noble wish, which the water will dispatch: stone, you must sink. Fate, you flow away, water-gulping. Water, become the gulper of the stone. It will get wet there, the water, and finally gulp the heavy stone. One hard heart fewer in the world. You all would have torn out your eyes and given them to me if it had been possible to live on this Earth with a delicate heart. How blessed you were then. Your day was hard and the cold was threatening [. . .] for half an hour, be sated with your luck. Your skin was song. Your advice was: see. It's not worth it to squabble and live in enmity. Your house is camouflaged. Your victories are near. Your last deed will be a coffin-unified rest-house for the final sleep. Why are you all so afraid? None of you will be left alive to weep for the others. Where is there a greater happiness? Your fated number, the 9, slowly turns itself on its head and becomes a 6, the number of death, which will sink head-over-heels with you into the grave. Where does it rain between nine and three? It rains between us lately. Wind Number Nine has become Six. When the paths are red, come running to us and everything will be white again. In the end, we will triumph over boring life. Hours, blushingly beautiful. Still and knowing now. We won't let ourselves be separated from one another. We won't share the fate of so many couples. We'll stay together even in death. But how, how can the problem be solved? An ordinary person is not permitted to buy pistols or potassium cyanide. That is the major problem. And where can we find the dignity of dying together, out of sorrow

or happiness? It happens less often than one might think.

Never believe yourself a stranger, Brother. I see myself timidly in you, field of peace. Question me, refresh me, so that I don't suffer too many ills. Round is the book of love. Far is the flight of revenge. I strike a bitter song on my lyre and quake. Unknown sir, I call on you. In cruel sorrow, I still command a spark of joy. Picture after picture of peace sank. Alas, I regret myself and thoughts pull like birds in autumn over the sea. No Ariadne stood under the sail and sang: O land! He arrived martyred and like a lament in iron fetters. Never wander, Thoughts, back into the beautiful bygone time of childhood. You cannot bear that. One—she was named Ariadne—was my child for a long time. A long journey, step up to the wall against wall in circles, to distract you and calm you. Never wander into the happy past, you couldn't bear it, I said to you just now. When you were a child, you were a child in the cold wind. The beautiful images of wood and star have been extinguished. Asiki Kidnar, your Indian chieftain, has grown old and white. Dark is the WAR in wind and circle. Atlas, art salon, three-wind, do you know, child? You were no fool when you were a child. Knee left and up against the wall! Mad-desire races into the dark How. You were a Wunderkind. You let A be I, and invented words like "Lastak," whose meaning was incredibly important to you. You were a poet as a child, but you forgot your early poems long ago and there was no one to write them down back then. Now you speak in the reasonable, unimaginative language of all people. Dark is the WAR in atlas, wind, and circle. Do you remember the old children's game "Three Questions Behind the Door"?

The tiger in the harp, under the Count's huts, wanders in three questions behind the door. The day, he rests in peace, he speaks in the clock. He questions the ancestors in the crypt, sadly wanders in there. Faraway speaks the knight Hunger, he found what he found: three questions behind the door that remain without an answer.

Who is the most bitter among us? Have you ever met the God-be-with-us? Where is the red nut iciest? Ask the tipsy mister or the white lady. Maybe they will have an answer . . . but the white lady lies on her bed, hooked on paleness, and the tipsy mister is busy holding a bottle of smelling salts under her nose because she is losing her senses. While doing so, he murmurs whatever goes through his mind:

"Ah! Love, wind's space, earth, you and he, Mr. Wood and the trees. It is what it is. My mouth speaks bitterly to your cold cheeks. The tired lukewarm love becomes hatred. The other becomes earth. Peace, you pale dame. A peace of giant Dadew in the white foliage of the flower Adea. You, who touched the blackbird's gentleman and are now wise and instructive, like the old raven Maduso." And the tipsy mister goes out, crying, and in this way misses the final words of the pale white lady, which she addresses to the world like a secret message: you will find the secret in a young city. Youth sings: now the sea is my harbor, is dream and hunt, the inner firm celebration of the spirit, which sometimes sends him dark and stony days and your hand and sense are immune in earnest. Your victories on this earth are found ancestors. Travel to the city of Jim-Sing. Go to the newest streets and find Amin the Ti. He says

yes, no, once, never, enemy, courage, I am you. Secret signature? Jade stone? You'll find the meaning in your last moment on Earth.

O sorrow, the old game on earth wrestled in death's gall. Pilara, Algoria, del Pastis. Misery! Agony of the universe. La perdu pardon. Lily of Alasteg. Day of the rose-song. Lapalis, lapis, la solide. Earth-day of agony, old game. It's nobody's business, the dying man said proudly to the empty walls and wiped the death-sweat from his forehead as if he wanted to begin to live once again.

Man, your hand said something. It's nobody's business. Man, what did your hand say? Hey! Don't forget to breathe. Then the man's hand said: deed! Dare to do that again. Your name is Sen-seaway. A wall stood there. Heh, man, it's dawning, that blows in the sand. Anne is there, man. Anne. Something is hanging there: a nest in the fir tree branch. Hey! Man, the cart is already driving down into Hades. One ėxerts, one objects, slowly it comes to an end. Sana-Getamea, madness of life, it ends now. My last hour is nobody's business, said the hand of the dying man. And he glanced at his lonely table: I, the loneliest, already mix my veins with ashes. I am the traveling mast. I travel at night. The name I is earnest. I want revenge. Mine is the realm of silk. Yours is the lonely table in the garret. It's only one o'clock? Stone in the wall, I am talking to you: Sam-Simae-Streak. If I end, it ends. Sima-Simae. Stroke the streak to the end, so that it finally reaches up to infinity. I feel the ice in my veins. Demoniac, loneliest me, of the earth. The last mast in the sea's sand slowly topples over and the waves crash together over it. Everything thaws this way on this trip, trace by trace. Feel the quiet mother-of-pearl smile. The white lips horribly

pull back from the yellow teeth. Lips of terror of silk. Life—a bad dream. Humans are smoke. All, dying, pray for revenge. Nothing but night. Miserable, I die among all these shards. Night! Courage! He, the fog, laughs at me. Stars, serious stars. Soon I will laugh about the mistake. Laugh, best to laugh. Break everything in half! Nose, stomach, right arm. Miserable cunning of love. Martyr! Alas, lights of the pale dream! He smiles at me, the life-deceiver! And brought nothing. Poor soul of the last Mohican.

Unica's heroes murdered. They scratch in the cold earth. Listen to them. Manitu is to thank for this, the cold hangman of the Aztecs' last dream Kuhir, Kunas, Kimona, the Last red man, of this Earth. Suna, the red eagle, limps. Kezme, the circling cold anger was a great chief. Tuma, Stoneheart, and Alkae murdered. Unkas, the last of the Mohicans, speaks to me. Listen to him:

Cold, sick, old is the mouth, O heart in the Earth's core. The last moon sank. It is very cold. Ravens speak around the lake. Deer and blackbird drinking tea. Raven, seer of disasters in the evening. The first stars surface. What do you have to say, Mr. K? And Mr. K only answers hesitantly:

The first toad died miserably at Hik. Nearby, the donkey spoke in the dream. The nose of poor Mr. K is bleeding. Lake, dark lake of the ravens. Breathing means life, means twining dreams of strange adventures that drive away boredom and let us forget the eternal thoughts of death . . .

A page slowly turns itself over in this book and lets a little hope appear:



And now I will tell the story of my Uncle Falada and the miraculous birth of his daughter Ambergris.

One sunny day a lonely but not quite hopeless man named Falada turned to his doctor with the following words: How should I set myself up to conceive a daughter through my nose and give birth to her through my ear, since I love scents and beautiful sounds?

—Then you should smell and listen for bodily strengths. This mixture of ambergris and musk will make you pregnant,—and the doctor pressed a small cobalt blue bottle into Falada's hand and told him to assiduously bring it to his nose wherever he happened to be.—You'll notice the first signs of your pregnancy as a light

pressure in your left ear. When a whistling and droning begins in your ear, betake yourself to an obstetrician, because your delivery will be soon. Goodbye.—Falada went about his business and soon, as if of its own accord, a little poem came to him:

—Swinging in the white cradle,
hinged at her hips,
little Ambergris goes through the meadow.
Eyelash-fringe shadows sink
Above the round pink bevels
Of her cheeks, which delicately . . .

And the song went no further than that, but Falada had found the name for his future daughter: AMBERGRIS!

After he became pregnant—for there was a friendly pecking in his left ear—he often and untiringly visited concerts and sound-paintings that were being performed at the time, and intoxicated himself with music from every century.

But when he looked in the mirror, he would have liked to hang his face on a nail because he looked so unimportant even though he would have liked to be a beautiful father for his Ambergris's sake.

On the thirty-third day after his conception and with hymns of joy in his heart, he dizzily went to the birth clinic, behind whose closed doors resounded the cries of pain of soon-to-be mothers. The obstetrician's apron was a single bloody child-fright, and Falada proudly turned his eyes away from it, because he was certain he would have a bloodless delivery.

—A head-birth.—That's how the midwife announced him, and

the obstetrician let a handwringing, knuckle-whitening piece of music resound on the gramophone, while Falada, with the ancient instinct of a father in labor, stood on his head. He then felt how something irretrievable was slipping and slipping out of him, and was caught by the midwife between her thumb and index finger, as he observed with a curious eye.—She even has real fingernails—said the completely dazed and foolish father Falada, as he looked at Ambergris, who was as big as a cat's eye.

The heavy, trembling mass of a new woman in labor was brought in on a stretcher, and Falada lowered his eyes before it.

He wrapped Ambergris in a tiny diaper and laid her in his breast pocket. He thanked everyone, paid the small fee that was charged here for a head-birth and betook himself to his doctor.

The doctor examined the girl through a sharp magnifying glass and granted her her first earthly nourishment, which consisted of a drop of patchouli perfume.

—And what should I do now?—asked Falada, a little embarrassed about his new circumstances.

—Nothing,—answered the doctor.

—I still plan to raise Ambergris. After all, I do have some ideals.

—Nonsense!—said the doctor, and raised his hands to heaven.—Raising children is a crime against humanity.—

The father made a stubborn face. Then, there was a knocking at his heart, and he took Ambergris out of his breast pocket to see what she desired. She leapt out of his hand, grew up, and vanished. And all that in a fast and breathtaking instant! A tiny diaper hung from Ambergris's round pink bevel like the eggshell on a chick.

—She's gone out onto the street naked!—shouted Falada.—She'll be locked up!—

Maybe the tree of knowledge was already swimming in her wake—smiled the doctor, and took his hat.—Or an Adam—cried the father, and they hastily left the house.

But they ran into a major quandary while on the search for the lone naked girl. Following Ambergris's example, all the young girls had pulled their dresses over their heads, and the flower-sellers had their hands full fastening white daisies onto thousands of round pink bevels.

Tired from not-finding, Falada and the doctor sat down on a terrace to drink a beer. While doing so, they became engrossed in suspiciously watching a five-year-old sitting in front of a mountain of raspberry ice cream. The little girl had a nose of unusual beauty, and Falada recognized his daughter Ambergris.—O, be quiet!—the child barked at him, before he had spoken a word.—When I wanted to rest in your head from the endless effort of coming into being, you recited verses. Laughable figure of indescribable idiocy!———Is that really my daughter?—asked the father, deeply wounded to the soul.—A daughter here, a daughter there—answered the doctor impatiently.—You probably failed to ask Ambergris for permission to be her father.—

At that moment, the shameless Ambergris strode away hand-in-hand with a black newspaper boy to the beach, to go bathing.

Falada hid his face in his hands and began to age.

She came back as a seventeen-year-old and pushed a black-and-white striped little boy in front of her in a stroller. "This is Omohona Omonene," she said, introducing grandfather Falada to

his grandchild.—The bastard will be drowned—gnashed Falada. But the doctor protectively laid his hand on the black woolly little head and from old habit reached for his hearing and seeing devices.—"It disdains to breathe, to see, to hear, and to smell"—he said.—Its soul is a little brass ball that slowly moves toward the dawning Sun in an aureole of noble chieftain-seeds like Saturn in its rings. This boy belongs to the genus of funster-children. For he was born from fun and one day he will become fun again—if that hour ever strikes for him.—I don't understand a word of your doctorly ecstasy, said Falada, while Ambergris gave the stroller a kick in one of those unexpected girlish moods. The little boy began to roll, and disappeared.

Ambergris, who had meanwhile taken on the persona of a dignified old lady, wished to immediately adopt her own father in her son's stead, which earned her the first slap of her life. She fell head over heels into her father's glass, but the doctor fished her out again and set her on his hat to dry.

A loudspeaker from the porcelain-police made the following announcement:

Lost black-and-white stripes of unknown origin are making mischief over the Hudson River. Because fun is forbidden according to Paragraph 99, the population is requested to deliver the disrupting object in question to the police for obliteration.

—A brass ball is rolling in circles around the brim of your hat—said Falada to his doctor—but Ambergris had already swallowed the ball. The black newspaper boy stormed by with the evening papers: Inhuman mother swallows her firstborn!

—Is it over now?—Falada asked his doctor. But the doctor was

of the opinion that it would keep on going, if everything went on by lawful means.

Falada put himself to bed with a small bottle of valerian drops to calm his nerves. He had already curled up to go to sleep when he noticed an unusually curious nose all alone on his pillow, approaching his bottle of valerian drops with proboscis-like movements.

Ambergris had appeared, and began to roll herself like a cat on her father's breast and wrap herself around her father's finger with belly-dancer spirals. Aghast, he flicked her onto the bedsheets, since he was beginning to be afraid of his own daughter.

Ambergris, by contrast, began to birth and birth from every orifice of her body an unending woolen band of ambergrisian children that inexorably began to fill the entire house.

Once upon a time a small, hopeful idea had promenaded in Falada's head, because the lonely fellow had wished for a daughter. And now a huge flock of female fiends were cooking, roasting, baking, knitting, laughing, and smoking weed criss-cross every which way, and Falada thoughtfully made his doctor aware of this.

The odor of boiled-down concentrate and boiled-away vapors drew from the lower rooms into his nose while he telephoned with his doctor.—We are currently one- to three-hundred people who were completely accidentally fathered, conceived, and delivered—from valerian. Ambergris, wherever you look. Who will pay for this?——Not I—said the doctor with certainty. But one calls them valerian-aids, and when the scent of newness volatizes in them, and when they are not allowed to smell like valerian, then

they will have to die, having hardly been born. I'll stop by your place in a moment.—

The father Falada paced uneasily around the room and a daughter quietly pushed herself against his heart, as small as before. In a feigned distractedness he clenched his fingers together around her and balled his fist.

And from the lower rooms upward, mischief was made and there was laughter at work.

The doctor came in and looked over the valerian brood with a quick glance. The spitting images carried each other around on their backs, hung themselves on the lamps and in the curtains or stuck themselves in each other's mouths like bonbons. Perplexed, the father raised his arms and the first- or third-born fell from his fingers with a black face and her tongue hanging out.

—You can't get rid of them like that—the doctor cried out unwillingly, and sucked a tear shed by the strangled ones into his pipette. The father, however, laid Ambergris in his postcard album as a souvenir and weighted it down with thick books, because he wanted to press her, so that he could glue her into his stamp album later.

The porcelain-police were brought in, and a total of 666 valerian aids were put in jail for breach of domestic peace, and from there, the very next day, 666-fold cases of death, straight into the crematorium.

But as they began to burn, the cats came by, because the air smelled like valerian, and the cats rolled rapturously on the ground and their meows sounded like Japanese celebratory music.

—I escaped one more time—said Falada at his window, grown lonely once again, and he watched the smoke climb out of the crematorium.

—Nonsense—said his doctor in a gentle voice. Show me your ear for a moment, so that we can take this story out of the world the same way that it came into the world.

And Falada did as he was told. The doctor emptied the tears of the dying Ambergris from his pipette into Falada's ear and carefully closed it up with a little ball of wax.—She will neither escape nor multiply—said the doctor,—and time will grow together around her like Sleeping Beauty's thicket. Till the next time we take a look at one another, my friend.—

Falada went about his business and only sometimes, when the mood irresistibly took him in the evening before going to bed, would he slowly hold the valerian bottle to his ear, and his ear would become an eye with which he could look into an endless remote distance at whose far edge a little girl sat in the snow of loneliness and played with her fingers. With the postal service of his thoughts, which did not always fall short of its goal, he sent her a pink-and-white striped peppermint stick and left it at that.

My days incline toward their end. Enough of the gruesome game. The wonderful last hour—will it not appear? In dust and earth become and become dust and send the everlasting winter. Round about it became evening and traveled with me, who had become a blessed child again, into the land of Howthewhere. O Winds, thousand brothers, let me pass away in your breath.



Christina Svendsen has translated works by Paul Scheerbart, Kurt Schwitters, Jean Arp, Dürs Grünbein, Francis Ponge, and others. She is currently working on a book manuscript titled *Stone, Steel, Glass: Architectures of Time in European Modernity*. She works as a Lecturer in Comparative Literature at Harvard University.

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This fierce fable of childbirth by German Surrealist Unica Zürn was written after she had already given birth to two children and undergone the self-induced abortion of another in Berlin in the 1950s. Beginning in the relatively straightforward, if disturbing, narrative of a young woman in a tower (with a bat in her hair and ravens for company) waging a psychic war against the parasitic son in her belly, *The Trumpets of Jericho* dissolves into a beautiful nightmare of hypnotic obsession and mythical language, stitched together with anagrams and private ruminations. Arguably Zürn's most extreme experiment in prose, and never before translated into English, this novella dramatizes the frontiers of the body—its defensive walls as well as its cavities and thresholds—animating a harrowing and painfully honest depiction of motherhood as a breakdown in the distinction between self and other, transposed into the language of darkest fairy tales.

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